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Paul Fein

Rarely has a non-Grand Slam match in a generational rivalry between young superstars meant as much as this duel at the 2025 ATP Finals.

Carlos Alcaraz had split the last eight Majors with Jannik Sinner (**left**), while the latter had won the season-ending tournament last year. The Italian desperately needed to defend his title.

One statistic told the stark truth about this increasingly lopsided rivalry: since the start of 2024, Sinner dominated the rest of the ATP Tour with a gaudy 129-5 match record against everyone except Alcaraz.

Against his kryptonite, he was an abysmal 1-7. "If Sinner loses this one, he thinks: I won two Majors [this year] and I'm this good, but I can't beat that guy," said former No. 1 Jim Courier. "That's why this match weighs so heavily on Sinner."

Sinner seems to thrive on pressure, though. We first learned about his sangfroid after he made his orange-clay 'carota' fans nervous wrecks before rallying from two sets down to beat Daniil Medvedev in the 2024 Australian Open final. "I like to dance in the pressure storm," he said afterwards. "I like it, because that's where most of the time I bring out my best tennis."

This was another critical time. His opponent, Alcaraz, was far superior to Medvedev, but so is the much-improved Sinner. The wiry-strong 6'3" Italian has honed his skills, expanded his repertoire, increased his strength and speed, and sharpened his tactics under the astute coaching of Darren Cahill and Simone Vagnozzi.

Riding a 30-match indoor winning streak, the 24-year-old Italian boasted a 20-1 record since losing the U.S. Open final to his nemesis. The fervent 12,500 Inalpi Arena spectators in Turin would also cheer,

SINCARAZ REBOOTED

With his second consecutive ATP Finals title, Jannik Sinner restored a hint of **renewed balance** against arch-rival Carlos Alcaraz.